Working Paper # 2

Incorporation of Certifications in Academics Program

Sponsored by Academics Directorate

Background

1. The Higher Education Commission (HEC), recognizing the critical importance of graduates' employability and professional mobility at both national and international levels, is committed to facilitating the development of academic programs that are closely aligned with market needs. HEC is strengthening curricula by integrating internationally acceptable certifications in curriculum to equip students with practical, job-ready skills alongside academic knowledge. This approach ensures that graduates gain not only strong theoretical foundations but also the hands-on experience valued by employers.

2. The aim of certifications is to equip students with practical, job-ready skills and improve their competitiveness in the job market. Priority is also being accorded to disciplines with high market demand by HEC, including Information Technology and Computer Science, Medical and Health Sciences, Business and Management, Agriculture, and Food Science.

Mechanism to accept Certifications:

3. To incentivize students to pursue subject-related certifications, a department may accept credit hours for certifications subject to the following conditions:

   a. Departments will ensure that the requirements of relevant accreditation bodies are met, even where the policy provides flexibility.
   b. Departments will process the cases for inclusion of specific certification in their certification pool through ACM before counting them for CHs.
   c. A department will consider approved certification in lieu of an elective course. Approved certifications, if not part of the approved pool, may be counted as additional on transcript for students.
   d. The department will recommend the certification along with the corresponding credit hours for elective replacement, while ensuring compliance with accreditation requirements.

e. Course Learning Outcomes (CLOs) may be mapped with the certification at a level comparable to the elective being replaced.

f. Certifications may be recognized for a minimum of 1 credit hour (CH) and a maximum of 3 CHs. Credit recognition will be aligned with engagement hours such that 1 CH corresponds to 16 contact hours of engagement, 2 CHs corresponds to 32 contact hours of engagement, and 3 CHs corresponds to 48 contact hours of engagement

g. **Validation & Assessment Mechanism**

   (1) The department will also conduct an assessment/test to validate the student's acquired skills, and the student must pass this assessment to earn certification credit(s).

   (2) Assessment/test would be conducted in Fall/Spring semesters only, along with End Semester Exams and certification would appear on transcript in the same semester.

   (3) Department will ensure that certifications must be valid (i.e., not expired) and verifiable with the issuing body. The respective department will ensure the authenticity of the certification before credit recognition

h. **Timeline**. Students may pursue certifications after enrollment in the respective degree program, subject to prior approval from the department. The student will be enrolled for the approved certification on Qalam (in Fall / Spring semester only) as per standard enrolment mechanism.

i. **Students Per Semester Load.** The department will ensure that the student's academic workload does not exceed the 21 CH limit while undertaking certification requirements.

j. **Grade.** Grade of certification would not count towards CGPA. A "Q-Qualified" grade will appear on the student transcript, and certification title would be mentioned on the transcript. Necessary modifications in transcript to be made by ICT (P&D) & Exam Dtes.

k. **Financial Implication**. There will be no financial liability on NUST for the certification. Student must pay the certification fee (if any) to the certificate issuing body.

l. **Academic honours / Medals**. If certifications are mandatory for a batch for a given number of CH, then all students will be eligible for Academic honours / Medals. In case a student voluntarily chooses certification against an elective, s/he would NOT be eligible for Academic honours/ award.

m. **For verification assessment**, faculty remuneration would be paid as per NUST ConnectEd policy.

n. **Course code** will be applied by Acad Dte in consultation with Exam Dte

o. **Process for Certification Approval.** The working paper for inclusion of certifications into curriculum of respective programs will be processed through the Academic Council Meeting (ACM) as per standard NUST practice. The working paper will include details on the relevance, authentication, and assessment mechanisms for certifications, as well as the credibility of the certification body.

Comments of Academic Directorate

4. Proposed revision was deliberated and endorsed in UCAP held on 30 Jan 2026

Recommendations of Academics Directorate

5. Proposed policy is recommended for implementation with immediate effect.

6. Academic Council is requested for the decision.